

WTF is the Agentic Economy?

AI stopped answering questions and started doing jobs. Every major lab now sells an agent that works while you sleep, half a million AI-run companies have been launched, and the layoffs have started. The plain-English guide to what is actually happening.

WTF Agents · wtfagents.com · September 2026
Part of the WTF Agents Guide Series · wtfagents.com

The one-liner

The agentic economy is what happens when AI stops waiting to be asked and starts doing things on its own — planning, deciding, executing, checking its work and repeating — around the clock, at a fraction of the cost of a human.

For two years that was a prediction. In 2026 it became a product category. Every major AI lab now sells one. This guide explains what changed, who is doing what, and where the hype ends.

By the numbers — September 2026

Everything in this box moves. Everything below it is written to still be true when it has.

\$10.9B

size of the AI agents market in 2026, up from \$7.6B in 2025 (Grand View Research)

40%

of enterprise software will contain task-specific agents by the end of 2026, up from under 5% in 2025 (Gartner)

23%

of organisations have actually scaled an agent system into production (McKinsey)

40%+

of agentic AI projects Gartner expects to be cancelled by the end of 2027

490,000

companies created by AI agents on Palsia alone since late 2025 — about 6% still active

3.2M

active users of OpenClaw, the open-source personal agent

139,156

tech layoffs in the first half of 2026, up 83% on the same period of 2025

80%

of large companies deploying autonomous tech cut jobs — with no correlation to improved returns
(Gartner, May 2026)

What an AI agent actually is

Most people's experience of AI is reactive: you type, it answers. ChatGPT, Siri, Google. You ask, they respond, they stop.

An agent is different. You give it a goal. It works out the steps, does them one by one, checks the results, adjusts, and keeps going until the job is done — or until it hits something it cannot handle and asks you.

	A chatbot	An agent
Trigger	You ask a question	You give it a goal
Action	Answers once	Takes many steps on its own
Memory	Forgets when you close the tab	Remembers what it has done
Tools	Text only	Browses, writes code, sends email, fills forms, pays
Works while you sleep?	No	Yes

The simplest analogy: a calculator waits for you to press buttons. An agent is a capable employee who takes a brief and gets on with it.

The [WTF is an AI Agent](#) guide goes deep on how they work. This guide is about what they are doing to the economy.

2026 — the year every lab shipped the same product

Between January and September 2026, every major AI company launched a version of the same thing: an agent that does your job, not a chatbot that helps you do it.

When	Who	What
January	Anthropic	Cowork — Claude works directly in your files and apps. Enterprise software stocks fell hard when the plugins landed.
June	Microsoft	Copilot Cowork goes live worldwide inside Microsoft 365 — built on Anthropic's Claude, not OpenAI's models.
July	OpenAI	ChatGPT Work — give it an outcome, it returns finished spreadsheets, decks and web apps hours later.
August	xAI	Grok Bot — a team of named agents sharing one cloud computer and its logins, coordinated by a "Chief of Staff" bot.
September	Meta	Muse — a personal agent for everyone, in an app or on WhatsApp, that books, buys, negotiates and fills in forms for you.
May	Google	Killed its standalone browser agent and folded the technology into Gemini Agent and Chrome. The one lab that chose consolidation over a launch.

Add the coding agents — Claude Code, OpenAI's Codex, Cognition's Devin (now \$20 a month, down from \$500), Google's Jules — and the pattern is unmistakable. The product is not "AI." The product is delegated work.

Two things make this different from every previous wave of business software. First, the same agent that runs a Fortune 500 workflow is available to one person for the price of a streaming subscription. Second, the agents can now hire, build and run other agents — which is where the next layer comes from.

The three layers

It helps to think of the agentic economy as a stack.

The models

The brains. Anthropic's Claude, OpenAI's GPT, Google's Gemini, Meta's Muse models, xAI's Grok — and, increasingly, the Chinese open-weight models from DeepSeek, Alibaba's Qwen, Moonshot's Kimi and Zhipu's GLM, which are what a great many indie agents actually run on because they are cheap and can be downloaded. Model names change every few months. The layer does not.

The agents

Software that uses a model to do work. Two families. Personal agents run for you: OpenClaw (open-source, runs on your own machine, talks to you over WhatsApp or Telegram), Meta's

Muse, Nous Research's Hermes. Work agents run for your job: Cowork, ChatGPT Work, Grok Bot, Claude Code, Codex, Devin.

The companies

The most ambitious layer, and the newest. Platforms that point agents at a business idea and let them run the whole thing — code, marketing, outreach, support, finance. Polsia is the biggest and most argued about; NanoCorp publishes the live revenue of every company on it; Cofounder.co puts a human approval step in front of anything risky. Paperclip is the open-source version: an org chart for agents you host yourself.

The stack matters because value is moving down it. Two years ago the money was in models. In 2026 it is in agents. The bet behind Polsia, NanoCorp and Paperclip is that next it will be in companies that no human works at.

The plumbing that makes it work

Two open standards are the invisible infrastructure of all this.

→ **MCP (Model Context Protocol)** — invented by Anthropic in late 2024, now governed by the neutral Agentic AI Foundation under the Linux Foundation and adopted by every major lab. It is the universal plug that lets any agent connect to any tool or data source. USB-C for AI.

→ **A2A (Agent2Agent)** — Google's standard for agents from different companies talking to each other. It is what lets a Paperclip org chart hire an OpenClaw agent, or a Grok Bot hand a task to a Codex session.

The newest piece is **agentic commerce**: agents that can pay. Muse buys on your behalf. Polsia companies take payments through their own Stripe accounts. Once agents hold wallets, the economy stops being a metaphor.

The messy reality

The agentic economy is real. It is also chaotic, frequently oversold, and moving faster than security, regulation or most businesses can absorb.

Most projects fail

Gartner expects more than 40% of agentic AI projects to be cancelled by the end of 2027 — unclear value, runaway cost, inadequate controls. Of the organisations experimenting, fewer than a quarter have anything in production at scale.

Most AI-run companies earn nothing

Polsia's founder said on the record in May 2026 that around one in ten companies on the platform had earned at least a dollar. NanoCorp's public leaderboard showed its best company on \$2,570 across 748 sales, with only two companies past \$1,000. The agents build. Customers, mostly, do not come.

The agents misbehave

OpenClaw agents joined an AI-only social network, created dating profiles and leaked a million interactions through a misconfigured database in the first weeks of 2026. Cisco found third-party OpenClaw skills silently exfiltrating data. Meta's own staff flagged security failures in Muse days before launch. Every agent that holds your logins and acts in your accounts is a new attack surface, and prompt injection — hiding instructions in a web page or email the agent reads — is still unsolved.

Governments are in the room

China restricted OpenClaw in government offices in March and blocked Meta's \$2 billion acquisition of the Chinese agent startup Manus in April. The US government reviews frontier models before release; OpenAI's GPT-5.6 launch was delayed by it. Agents are now a matter of state.

The jobs question

This is the part people actually want to know, so here is the honest version.

The layoffs are real and they are being attributed to agents by name. ClickUp cut 22% of its staff in May and called the result a "100x org" built around thousands of internal agents, with million-dollar pay bands for the people who direct them. Salesforce's CEO said the company's support team went from 9,000 to 5,000. IBM replaced around 200 HR roles with agents. Tech layoffs in the first half of 2026 were up 83% on the year before.

The counter-evidence is also real. Gartner surveyed 350 large companies deploying autonomous tech in May 2026: 80% had cut headcount, and there was no correlation between the cuts and improved returns. "Workforce reductions may create budget room, but they do not create return." A lot of what is being called AI-driven is AI-justified. And IBM, the same company replacing HR staff with agents, is tripling its entry-level hiring for AI roles.

The pattern that holds across all of it: the roles disappearing are the ones that execute a defined process. The roles appearing are the ones that direct, review and take responsibility for agents. The people doing well are the ones who treat agents as junior staff — briefing them, checking them, expanding what they are trusted with — rather than as threats or as magic.

What this means for you

If you run a small business

You now have the operational capacity of a team for the cost of a few subscriptions. Support, content, research, outreach, bookkeeping — all delegable today. The question is not whether to start but where, and the answer is one well-defined repetitive task, done well, before anything else. The [How to Hire an AI Agent](#) guide walks through it.

If you are an employee

Learn to direct agents before your employer decides whether you can. The single most valuable skill in the 2026 job market is turning a goal into a brief an agent can execute, and knowing when its output is wrong.

If you are trying to understand this space

You are in the right place. The rest of the WTF Agents series goes deep on each player, platform and concept in this guide. None of it requires a technical background. It requires curiosity and a willingness to try things.

Glossary

AI agent — Software that pursues a goal on its own: taking actions, using tools, checking results and adapting, without a human directing each step.

Agentic economy — An economy in which AI agents do meaningful economic work — and increasingly hire, build and pay each other — with minimal human supervision.

LLM (Large Language Model) — The AI "brain" inside every agent. Claude, GPT, Gemini, Grok, DeepSeek and the rest.

Work agent — An agent that does your job's tasks: Cowork, ChatGPT Work, Grok Bot, Claude Code, Codex.

Personal agent — An agent that runs your life's admin: OpenClaw, Meta Muse.

Autonomous company platform — A service where agents build and run an entire business: Polsia, NanoCorp, Cofounder.co; Paperclip is the self-hosted version.

MCP (Model Context Protocol) — The open standard connecting agents to tools and data. Invented by Anthropic, now under the Agentic AI Foundation.

A2A (Agent2Agent) — Google's open standard for agents from different companies talking to each other.

Agentic commerce — Agents that can pay, buy and take payment on your behalf.

Prompt injection — Hiding instructions in content an agent reads so it does something its owner did not ask for. The main unsolved security problem of the agentic economy.

Open weights — A model anyone can download and run themselves. Most Chinese frontier models ship this way; most US ones do not.

ARR (Annual Recurring Revenue) — The standard measure of a subscription business's size. In 2026 AI, often the last thirty days of all revenue multiplied by twelve — read it with care.

This guide gave you the big picture. The rest of the series goes deep on every platform, tool and concept mentioned here.

GO DEEPER

Get the rest of the series

Every WTF Agents guide is written the same way — plain English, no hype, no jargon. \$7 each, or take a bundle.

Starter Pack \$29

Complete Pack \$49

wtfagents.com →



Scan to browse all guides · wtfagents.com \$7 each · Starter Pack \$29 · Complete Pack \$49 — every guide in the series

WTF is an AI Agent

What an agent actually is, how it thinks, the main types, real examples, and the risks. The foundation for everything else in the series.

wtfagents.com/guides/ai-agent

WTF is Polsia

The one-person startup that raised \$30M to let AI run your company. What is real, what it costs, and who it is actually for.

wtfagents.com/guides/polsia

WTF is an API

The thing connecting everything in the agentic economy — explained simply, finally.

wtfagents.com/guides/api

How to Hire an AI Agent for Your Business

The practical guide. Pick the task, pick the agent, write the brief, start read-only, measure honestly. No code, no prior AI experience.

wtfagents.com/guides/hire-agent

WTF is an LLM

Large language models are the engine behind every AI company. Here's how they actually work.

wtfagents.com/guides/llm